



CARDS AGAINST THE CLOUD

Rules of play, house rules, and printing notes

What this is

Cards Against the Cloud is what happens when Cards Against Humanity gets an AWS certification and Magic: The Gathering discovers CloudFormation. It is a party game for cloud architects, DevOps engineers, platform teams, and that one person who insists their Terraform module is basically art. The cards mix dark humor, cloud jargon, and just enough Lambda cold start lag to make any architect cry. If you have ever had to explain a five figure invoice to a CFO who thought the cloud was free, you already know how to play.

The deck ships with 100 black cards and 450 white cards. Black cards ask the question. White cards are the reason you are not sleeping tonight.

What you need

Three to twenty players, though the game is at its best with four to eight. A printed deck. A flat surface. Optional but strongly recommended: a group that has survived at least one production incident together, because the humor lands harder when it is load bearing.

Setup

Shuffle the two decks separately and keep them apart. Deal ten white cards to each player face down, and leave the rest of the white deck within reach. Put the black deck in the middle where everyone can see it.

Pick a first judge. The traditional method is whoever got paged most recently, though whoever broke production most recently works just as well. The judge role rotates to the left after every round, the same way on-call does and with roughly the same enthusiasm.

Playing a round

The judge draws a black card and reads it out loud. Everyone else picks the white card from their hand they think will land best and passes it to the judge face down. Nobody signs their work. Anonymity is the entire point, and it is the only part of this game with proper access controls.

The judge shuffles the submissions so nobody knows who played what, then reads each combination out loud and picks a winner. Read them all, and read them with commitment. Half the comedy is in the delivery, which is also true of most architecture reviews.

Whoever wins the round keeps the black card. We call these Service Credits, which is fitting, because they are worth almost nothing and you have to ask for them.

Everyone draws back up to ten white cards, the judge role passes to the left, and you go again. Repeat until someone wins or someone gets paged for real.

Pick 2 and Pick 3 cards

Some black cards ask for more than one answer, and they say so in the bottom right corner. Play your cards in the order you want them read, because the order usually is the joke. Draw back up to ten at the end of the round the same as always.

Winning

First player to seven Service Credits wins. Alternatively, play until the pizza runs out, which is the more common ending and arguably the more honest one. Whoever holds the most Service Credits when the group loses interest is declared the winner and receives nothing, exactly like a real SLA claim.

Judging

The judge picks whatever they think is funniest. There is no rubric, no scoring matrix, and no appeals process. The judge's ruling is final, which makes this the only part of your job with genuinely clear ownership.

Two pieces of advice for judges. Reward the answer that makes the table laugh rather than the one that is technically most correct, because technical correctness is what got us into this mess in the first place. And if two submissions tie, read them both again in a slightly different tone and go with your gut, which is what your architecture review board does anyway.

House rules

None of these are required. Pick the ones that fit your group and ignore the rest, which is also the correct way to adopt a framework.

Rebooting the hand. Once per game, a player may discard their entire hand and draw ten new cards. It costs one Service Credit if they have one to spend. This is the only supported remediation path.

The blameless postmortem. If a card lands a little too close to something that actually happened, the player who submitted it may tell the real story in thirty seconds or less. If the table agrees it was a good story, that player takes a bonus Service Credit. Naming the guilty is optional. Everyone knows anyway.

Cloud wars. For mixed crowds, have every player declare allegiance to AWS, Azure, GCP, or OCI before the first round. Any winning answer that mocks the player's own provider is worth two Service Credits. Self awareness should pay.

The OCI rule. Any card that mentions OCI earns a bonus Service Credit for whoever plays it. Somebody has to give that team a win, and it is clearly not going to be the market.

Vendor lock-in. The judge may declare a theme before reading a black card, such as security, cost, or Kubernetes. Only submissions that fit the theme are eligible, and migrating off the theme mid-round is not permitted. That is the joke.

Sev 1. Put a thirty second timer on submissions. Anyone who misses the window is out of the round. This is a party game about incidents, so a little manufactured panic is thematically appropriate.

Gartner's choice. Any player may nominate one losing answer per round as visionary. If the table agrees, that answer's owner takes a Service Credit. Placement is subjective and possibly influenced by who bought the most analyst time.

The change freeze. Nobody is allowed to explain their card. If the joke does not land on its own, it does not land. This rule exists because we all know the guy.

Happy hour mode. Take a drink whenever someone says "well, actually," whenever a card describes something that happened to your team this quarter, or whenever anyone opens a sentence with "in my last role." Be sensible about this, and please do not do it while holding the pager.

Printing and assembly

The black and white card files are laid out nine cards per page at 2.5 by 3.5 inches, which is standard playing card size. Print at 100% scale and turn off any "fit to page" or "shrink to printable area" setting, because those shift the cut lines and you will notice by card forty. Page one of each file is a cover sheet, so start printing from page two.

Cardstock in the 200 to 300 gsm range will feel like a real deck. Regular paper works fine for a first playtest and costs almost nothing, which is more than can be said for the subject matter. A paper trimmer will save you roughly an hour compared to scissors. If you want the deck to survive more than one happy hour, sleeve the cards.

Print the white deck first. The black cards use a full bleed black fill and will make your printer file a complaint with HR.

A note on content

The deck leans dark, sarcastic, and occasionally suggestive, in the tradition of the game it parodies. It stays away from anything built on racism, abuse, or explicit material. If a card does not suit your group, pull it. There are 550 of them and nobody will miss one. Skimming the deck before you hand it to your team offsite is time well spent, and it is the closest thing this game has to a pre-deployment check.

Where to get the decks

Both card decks and this rules document live in the project repo:

<https://github.com/michaelgeiser/cards-against-the-cloud/>

Grab the latest files there. Cards get added, retired, and rewritten as new services ship and old ones get deprecated, which in this industry is roughly weekly. If you write a card good enough to hurt, send it in.

Credits and fine print

Cards Against the Cloud is an original deck. Every card in it was written for this game. The name is a parody reference to Cards Against Humanity, and this deck is not affiliated with, endorsed by, or connected to Cards Against Humanity LLC, nor to Amazon Web Services, Microsoft, Google, Oracle, IBM, or any other company named on a card. All product names belong to their respective owners, who are presumably too busy shipping features to care.

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Created by Michael Geiser. Geisersoft.